

BARRIERS TO COMMUNICATION

INTRODUCTION: Communication is one of our basic needs. We require to communicate with many people for personal and professional purpose. But while communicating we may face many hurdles or problems. Sometimes the message is not passed properly or gets lost. There are chances of misunderstanding between the sender or the receiver. Sometimes language used in the communication is not understood properly. This results into Communication breakdown or communication failure. There are many reasons behind the problems in the communication process. Let's study the Communication Barriers in detail.

Definition of the Barrier to Communication: 'Any obstacle or problem in the process of Communication which hinders/obstructs the process of Communication is called Barrier.'

Barriers are part of process of Communication. Whenever we are communicating we encode and decode. We use various channels for passing messages. At any level or at any moment or stage there can be problems in communication process. Sometimes the sender may not use proper language that the receiver will understand. Receiver may not be able to Decode properly. There can be lot of noise in the surrounding which can disturb us. It rarely happens that barriers do not arise in the communication process. Many times barriers arise in the minds of the sender and receiver. The intended messages are not sent to the receivers .

Types of Barriers: We face many barriers while communicating. These barriers can create obstacles in the communication process. These barriers are classified into the following types.

1. Physical or Environmental Barriers: The Barriers in the surrounding or in the environment are the physical barriers.

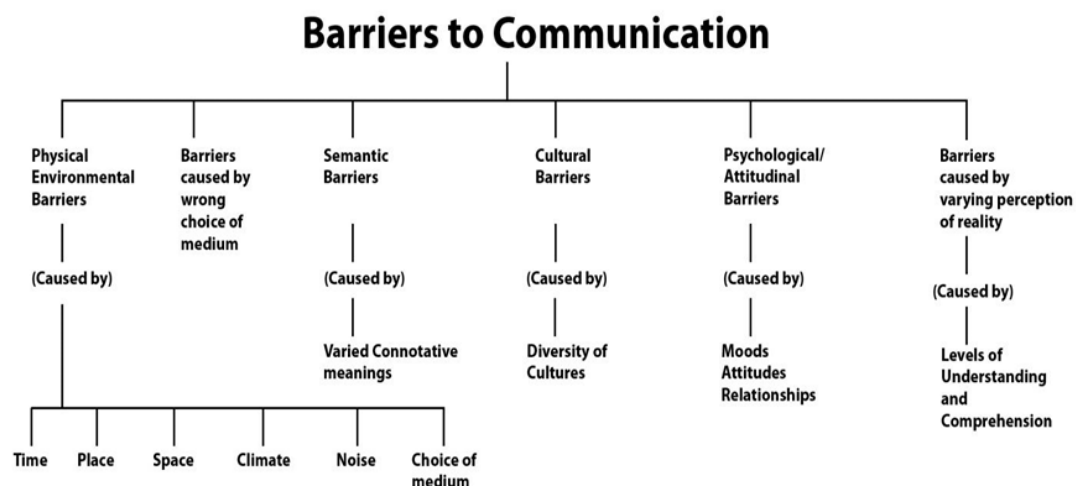
2. Language/Semantic or Linguistic Barriers: Barriers arising due to the different language or differences in language can create problems in communication. Semantic Barriers means the problems arising because of the different meanings of the words.

3. Psychological Barriers: Barriers or problems arising due to the stress or psychological problems are psychological barriers. It is difficult to accept and overcome these barriers.

There are various problems and difficulties in the process of communication which often result in the occurrence of the barriers to communication. Communication barriers are interferences or obstacles which affects not only the transmission of idea or information but also the understanding and acceptance of it. It has an effect on entirely preventing communication, filtering part of it, or giving it an incorrect meaning. The three main causes for the barriers in communication are due to:

1. The deficiencies of the sender
2. The deficiencies of the listener
3. Inappropriate means of communication

The various barriers to the process of communication are given as follows.



Question: What is the meaning of Physical Barrier/Environmental Barriers ? Give examples of Physical Barriers.

1. Physical Barriers : Many barriers arise in the surroundings or our environment. These barriers create problems or confusion in communication.

- Noise: Traffic Noise or noise of machines in factory create disturbances in communication. Noise pollution is biggest contributor or environment pollution in India.

- Time and Distance :Physical distances between people can create major problems in communication. Time zones around the world are not same. Due to differences in timings between countries we have to adjust with the time difference of that country.
- Defects in Communication Systems: Many times the instruments or machines used in communication such as Telephones, Fax or Computer can develop problems. The network of Internet can fail or the Mike or Microphone used in the programmes can create loud noise. Due to excess rains or natural calamity it becomes difficult to use the instruments properly. The failure of Electronic power also results into communication loss or messages are not sent properly.
- Wrong Selection of Medium : Medium means the objects used in communication eg. Emails, Mobile Phones or Telephones etc. The correct medium is necessary. The improper use of some machines such as Emails can delay the messages.
 - High Temperature and Humidity: Excess Temperature or heat or cold Temperature create difficulties in communication

Many times human physical defects such as stammering ,bad hearing, failure of communication channels and bad handwriting also create misunderstanding in learning the message.

Q.What is the meaning of Language or Semantic Barrier?

2.Language Barriers: Barriers arising due to differences in languages, words meaning or pronunciation can create confusion among the people. Linguistic means related to the language. Semantic means the meaning of the words.Following are some of the examples of language barriers.

- Different Languages or lack of Common Language can create obstacles in Communication. A person who does not understand the native language or even foreign language cannot communicate well. This becomes very difficult situation.
- Multiplicity of words: words can have different meanings. Word power is gift to human beings but at the same times multiple meaning or spellings of the words can create the problems in communication.
- Words with similar pronunciation but different meaning [Homophones]also create problems in communication. E.g. Except-accept, fair-fare, council-counsel,principal-principle[etc].
- Jargon words[Technical words]used by professionals such as Engineers/Doctors or any other professionals. Many times, jargon words are used unintentionally. But common people or those who do not understand the meaning of these words face problems.
- By-passed Instructions: Means many times short cuts are used while passing the messages. Eg. A Manager ordered the newly appointed secretary to go and burn the C.D.She literally burned it . He meant to copy the C.D.

Question:What is the meaning of Psychological Barrier?

3.Psychological Barriers:

Psyche means mind. Psychological barriers arise in the minds. Human mind is a very complex thing to understand. We face many times some conflicts due to situations or surrounding events. So these barriers are bound to arise. But the real problem is that people do not accept that these barriers exist in their minds. Due to status, old age and ego problems many times psychological barriers are created. These are difficult to overcome. Because people do not accept that they face barriers or they lack proper understanding to face the world. The following are situations or examples of psychological barriers.

1. Ego: 'I' Attitude means I am great feeling can create barrier in mind. Ego barriers create conflict in human relations.
2. Prejudice: bias[wrong opinion] about people on the basis of community, caste, religions or on personal basis is very negative for communication. Prejudice can hamper the communication.
3. Emotions and feelings : Emotional Disturbances of the sender or receiver can distort[change] the communication .
4. Halo Effect: like or dislike about a person can create halo or horn effect. This can affect communication.
5. Self Image: Positive or Negative image about self is the way of looking at the world. Negative self-image can destroy or hamper communication . Such people always think negatively and do not look at the things or events properly.
6. Filtering in Messages: Messages are filtered [changed] intentionally. We always try to defend ourselves or protect ourselves during some problems so that many times messages are changed by the inferiors
7. Closed Mind : Most of the time our minds are closed or not able to learn new things. With old age or change in attitude this problem is observed. This is also a very barrier in communication.
8. Status : Status create barriers in the employees . Higher or lower status create obstacles in thinking or mixing with people. People keep distance while communicating due to status barriers.
9. Perceptions :The way we look at the world or attitude determines our Communication strategy. Wrong or negative perceptions can create difficulty in communication . People who have negative perceptions or think negatively look at every thing or event negatively.
10. Poor Retention : ability to retain the message or remember is important. But if it is poor then communication becomes difficult.
11. Interest and Attitudes : Interests and Attitudes of people determines communication strategy. Lack of interest or wrong attitude can lead improper communication.
12. Day-Dreaming: Many students have habits of dreaming or thinking about something else when some lecture is going on or talk is going on. This obstructs the communication and messages are not reached properly.

Question:What is the meaning of the Socio-cultural Barriers?

4.Socio-Cultural Barriers:

Culture is way of life, values or principles .Cultural differences between people can create barriers . Different religious practices are followed around the world. Due to many time differences in the culture can create misunderstanding in communication. Due to globalization and liberalized policies in business, people around the world are travelling and working in multinational corporates or companies. This led to mixing or intermingling between people But due to differences in language, religious practices, dressing styles, food habits many times people get confused and are not able to understand each other properly. This led to communication failure. The following are examples or socio-cultural barriers.

- **Concept of Time :** The time is not perceived similarly across the cultures. In Western culture Time is important. In Asian culture Time is taken leisurely. The concept of punctuality differs in cultures.
- **Assumptions about social strata or caste system.** Caste system is observed in India. But in every culture some kind of differences in the society in the form of religion, community differences or sects or class division is observed. We should not always assume someone superior or inferior because of caste or class system.
- **Etiquettes and Mannerisms:** In every society or cultures different types of mannerisms are observed. This includes rule of behaviors or how to follow certain code of conduct . Different forms of address and salutation or different methods of dressing [formal or informal wearinø] are observed. This can be confusing sometimes.

Food preparation method or serving methods are not the same. There are certain expected norms of eating food in meeting .These are called dining etiquettes.

- **Body Language[Non Verbal Behavior]** methods around the world are not same. There can be misunderstandings because of this.
- **Proximity[Concept of Space]**differs from culture to culture. In some culture close distance between people is not approved. In some culture close distance is accepted.
- **Value system** is not same across the cultures. Values or good behavior or ethical principles guide in our life. But the methods of these value system is not same around the world.
- **How to overcome the Barriers?**

- **Physical Barriers:** By overcoming defects in communication system ,by controlling noise ,physical distance Physical Barriers can be overcome to some extent. Though we can't overcome some physical barriers such as time , distance or defects in machine, we can control Physical barriers to some extent. Efforts are required by all people to overcome physical barriers.
- **Language Barrier:** Lot of efforts are required to overcome Language Barriers. There should be respect for any language before learning new language. It requires many efforts

to learn foreign language. So learning the correct pronunciation and accent and improving vocabulary [word power] we can master a language. We have to improve listening skills and then only language can be understood properly.

- **Psychological Barriers:** It is true that psychological barriers are difficult to overcome or solve. There must be acceptance of one's mistakes or limitations. This will lead to understanding of human life. People do not accept their faults or limitations. This leads to many problems. We have to be humble and respectful towards other people. Many times the sender and the receiver are not in proper frame of mind. So this creates problems in Communication. Misunderstanding, lack of interests, mental and physical disturbance can cause problems because of that. Efforts should be taken by superiors and all reporting people to overcome the problems.
- **Socio –Cultural Barriers:** These Barriers can be overcome by proper study of other cultures. It is very much essential to learn new cultural values and observing people and accepting their cultures. We have to develop open mindedness in this regard. We have to understand the mannerisms of other people.

Communication barriers are like a brick wall which if not broken timely will result in negatively affecting every function of the organization, be Human Resource Management, Sales and Marketing, Operations, Research and Development, Public Relations or maintaining goodwill of the organization among all its stakeholders. So a way has to be found through wall..



Since communication is the life blood of an organization it is very important that efforts are made at the organizational as well as individual level to overcome the communication barriers. So efforts at individual level and interventions at organizational level are required to identify the barriers hindering the communication flow within and outside the organization, so that proper action can be taken to address the problems related to effectiveness of communication. Although it is not possible to eliminate all the barriers, effort should be made to minimize them to extent possible in the interest of the organization.

The following guidelines are offered in this regard:

5.1. Well defined organizational policy: Organizations should have well defined, clear and widely circulated communication policies related to the dos and don'ts of the communication within the organization as well as communication with external stake holders. Such policies will minimize misunderstanding and promote effective flow of communication.

For Example: It should be clearly mentioned in the relevant section of the HR policy that who will provide the appraisal feedback to the employees at various levels of the organization. Or it should be a part of the sales manual that what information should be given about the company to the prospective client in sales presentation by an executive.

5.2 Asking for feedback: In order to make communication effective, managers should actively seek feedback from subordinates about their communication messages. Feedback reduces the probability of confusion and discrepancy between the messages sent and received.

For Example: After summing up the decisions taken at the end of the meeting of a team or committee, the convener or the chairperson of the committee may ask the members one by one to share with others what are the tasks that they have agreed to undertake within a particular deadline.

5.3 Restructuring: To facilitate an enabling communication environment, effort should be made to simplify the complex organization structure through reorganization activities.

For Example: Reorganization may involve reducing authority layers and establishing clear authority and responsibility relationship or adopting open door communication policy by superiors with respect to their subordinates or starting the use of technology like internet to deliver the messages through emails for faster dissemination of information.

5.4 Employee Training & Development: To make the employees efficient communicators, organizations can arrange various training and development programs for them.

For Example: When new employees join the organization they should be given orientation seminars with respect to company mission, goals, policies, rules and regulations, procedures, etc. This can greatly enhance their future communication effectiveness in the organization as well as with respect to the external stakeholders. The employees can also be provided training on computers and other electronic means of communication.

5.5 Developing informal relationship: Informal relationship can play a vital role in promoting communication. Hence an effort should be made to encourage informal communication along with the formal communication.

For Example: Along with sending a circular to all the members of the department inviting suggestions for a solution to a particular problem, the manager should also reach out to the people and talk to them personally for gaining insights from them. This will ensure the return communication from the members, speed up the communication, help build informal relationship and motivate employees.

5.6 Choosing appropriate media: Effectiveness of communication largely depends on the suitability of media. So, the media should be selected considering some factors such as the importance of the message, communication environment, knowledge of the receiver etc.

For Example: If the message is urgent and requires immediate action oral communication over telephone is the most suitable medium to communicate. Or if the brand and product information has to be given to the rural people then wall paintings in bright colors may be the best medium of communication.

5.7 Reducing information overload: Communication system becomes defective if more information flows at a time than is necessary. To resolve this problem, only necessary information should be conveyed.

For Example: Information Overload can be reduced by decentralizing routine decision making so that communication channels can be shortened to make the communication faster and effective.

5.8 Communication audit: To improve communication in the organization it is advisable to conduct communication audit at regular intervals. Communication audit means examining and evaluating communication networks, functions and effectiveness.

For Example: A detailed communication audit in an organization may lead the top management to realize that formal communication channels are designed in such a manner that only downward communication is possible in the organization which is hampering recognition of young talent. So after communication audit top management may initiate the process of building communication networks which facilitate upward communication for better growth of the company.

So we have understood the ways through which the communication barriers can be minimized. Such efforts have to be continuous and the management should be fully committed to work on these measures. Now let us summarize what we have learnt in this module...

6. Summary

As we have discussed in the preceding sections, communication is considered as the life blood of organization, it is the way through which the details of the goals, objectives, strategies, orders and policy of organization are explained to the employees of the organization and by the way of communication the organization comes to acquire the information about their rivals, the opportunities offered by the markets and threats to the organization. So communication effectiveness is a must for organization. But sometimes the message does not get decoded by receivers in original form as it is encoded by senders because of some kind of barriers. These barriers are called communication barriers. These barriers can be Semantic, Psychological, Organizational or Personal. The barriers to communication must be identified as early as possible by the people concerned so that appropriate steps can be taken to remove these barriers so that, information can be communicated effectively in the organization as well as outside the organization..